

One Choice Changes Everything

CHOOSE YOUR WORK



Redefine Success and Discover the Work
That Makes You Feel Fully Alive

DAN DOBOS

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What If My Whole Life Has Been Wrong?

Why do so many people experience a deep sense of regret at the end of their lives?

Ivan Ilych, a legal practitioner revered by his peers, had a frightening thought on his deathbed: *What if my whole life has been wrong?* He had climbed every rung of the professional ladder, conformed to every social expectation, yet still felt an emptiness untouched by his many accomplishments.

What if that were you? What if, lying on your deathbed, you realized that despite following all the rules, you overlooked what mattered most? What if you chose the wrong career? What if you spent your time on things that never really mattered? What if you were skilled at your job, but it never brought you any joy?

It's a terrifying thought that your whole life has been wrong. But what's even more unsettling is that this is not just a hypothetical idea.

Bronnie Ware, a palliative care nurse for many years, documented the regrets shared by patients in the final stage of their lives. The most common regret was: *I wish I'd had the courage to live a life true to myself, not the life others expected of me.*

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The insights from Ivan Ilych and Bronnie Ware about living meaningfully remind me of when my dad migrated from Romania to Australia. When his family first arrived, they couldn't afford chairs, so they used fruit boxes from the grocer instead. Even today, at various moments — like when I sit on a comfortable chair — I visualize my dad sitting on a fruit box and my heart swells with emotion. I become almost teary-eyed as I feel my chest flooded with energy, which then envelops my entire body.

This sense of awe and gratitude for being able to live in Australia fills me with determination and focus, reminding me that I won the lottery at birth and that many people are deprived of the same opportunity. It makes me appreciate that each moment is irreplaceable, that I have an obligation to work hard, think hard, and live to my full potential.

My father's story helped me realize how much life has to offer. It made me notice that many people have stable careers, possess reasonable intelligence, and lead respectable lives. They do all the things their culture and families programmed them to do. They honor their commitments, study diligently, adhere to the rules, get to work on time, pay taxes, complete paperwork, raise families, retire, play with their grandchildren, and finally, they die. While this is an entirely valid way to live, a nagging question lingers: Is this all there is?

Despite outward appearances of success, many reach the end of their lives grappling with a profound sense of regret because they never pursued their innermost desires. They got caught up in life's mundane distractions instead of embracing the depth of what life has to offer. While there were many happy occasions, these were experienced without fully comprehending that their deepest aspirations were quietly being overlooked.

It's as if they somehow believed they had an unlimited supply of time, even though the finite nature of life is undeniable. The average person spends 45 years working, which amounts to approximately 90,000 hours. This book urges you to examine your own life so that when you reach its end, you look back without the haunting regret that plagued Ivan Ilych.

This book is for you if you sense there's more to life than the same document, the same spreadsheet, and the same meetings on repeat. If you seek work that resonates with your core, if you desire a life imbued with a deeper meaning, then this book is for you. If you don't address these aspirations, the ensuing restlessness can lead to a life half-lived, untapped potential, and a lingering shadow of what could have been.

This book is for you if you want to stop suffering in comfort and begin living to your full capacity. Let's discover your deepest truth, redefine what success means to you, and begin a fulfilling new chapter in your journey.

I personally confronted these issues when I encountered the book that changed my life.

The Book That Changed My Life

I have always been good at math. In eighth grade, I got 100% on the final exam. I continued to excel in math throughout high school and received many first-class honors in Engineering/Law at the University of Melbourne.

I picked engineering because of my proficiency in math, rather than seeking out what truly excited me. While there were aspects of my studies that I enjoyed, the type of work covered in civil engineering left me uninspired. By overvaluing my math skills, I failed to pursue what really mattered to me. I suffered from the curse of competence.

After graduating from the University of Melbourne, I successfully made it through a grueling six-round interview process at an elite consulting firm. My time in the corporate world taught me a lot about rigor and structure. It also helped me realize that I feel most fulfilled when helping people grow as opposed to focusing solely on commercial outcomes. So at twenty-five, I chose my work for the first time by leaving my corporate job. I began a coaching business to show students an easier way to study.

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Each morning, I spent an hour writing, exploring ideas that intrigued me. One day, I decided to write *Choose Your Work* as a gift for my kids because I hoped it would help them cultivate meaningful and fulfilling lives.

I never would have expected that I was writing this book for myself as much as I was writing it for my kids. It was like the book had a mind of its own, working on me while I thought I was working on it. I came to understand that the book that will most impact your life isn't a bestseller recommended on social media; it's the book that you write yourself. It turned out that writing this book was accidentally the greatest gift that I have ever given myself.

Each morning for two years, I blocked out 9 a.m. to noon to work on this project and went to bed every night looking forward to this uninterrupted time. Ordinarily, my phone would constantly distract me. But during these morning sessions, my focus was intense because the work energized me — so much so that at times, I felt waves of energy going down my spine. It felt like I was doing the work that I was meant to be doing.

There were many challenging moments. Sometimes, I got stuck and felt like I had no idea how to progress. Even then, I enjoyed being defeated by the work. I enjoyed dancing with difficulty. I embraced the roller coaster through its ups and downs. I hung on tightly because I could feel in my bones that this work resonated with my true self. It would have been easy to keep running my business as usual, but something deep inside me had already rejected ease and comfort a long time ago. So I kept going, uncertain as to what would come next but completely certain that I was on the right path.

As I became more absorbed in writing, I began to notice a pattern. I would work intensely from 9 a.m. to midday in a state of bliss. Then midday would arrive and I would have to stop. I would feel a sharp pang of sadness as I extricated myself from what I loved doing to deal with the demands of my business. As this pattern repeated itself, I became aware that something was amiss.

As much as I greatly enjoyed working in the business, it had a very particular rhythm. It required intense attention to detail and juggling many moving parts, with each day fragmented into countless short bursts of energy to address the multitude of tasks and people requiring attention.

In contrast, I discovered that writing energizes me due to its singular focus. Writing this book allowed me to immerse myself in a web of ideas and develop a perspective on a neglected topic. As the writing pulled me in with an increasingly strong magnetic force, I came to realize that deep down, there was nothing that I wanted more than to think and write all day. It then dawned on me that, as the author of *Choose Your Work*, it would be unacceptable to ignore this very same principle in my own life.

And so, once again, I chose to pursue the work that called me. While I believed that staying in the business would be more financially rewarding, something deep within compelled me to commit fully to writing. I had always lived well below my means, which meant I could risk hiring someone to take over my role in the business. I faced setbacks recruiting the right person but decided that I would do whatever it took, for however long it took, to move forward with my plan. Eventually, I found someone to replace me.

Was it easy to choose my work? Absolutely not. But without a doubt, it felt right in every cell of my body.

My journey helped me grasp the real difference between a strength and a weakness, which is further explored in *Chapter 8: How to Overcome the Curse of Competence*. Despite ignoring my true strengths, my sheer grit and determination led me to a highly sought-after corporate job and a successful coaching business. But when you choose the work that you are meant to do, your work will light you up. It will capture your attention and give you an immense surge of energy. It will make you feel more powerful, bring you joy and enthusiasm, create an enriching inner journey, and make you feel fully alive.

Choosing your work means pursuing the kind of work that energizes you and brings a deep sense of meaning. This often involves letting go of

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others' expectations and embarking on an uncertain yet deeply fulfilling path. But if you choose your work, it becomes a true expression of who you are, not merely a means to an end.

Why We Unknowingly End Up in Unfulfilling Careers

Firstly, we need to examine what we are told about work. We're often told things like, "If it were fun, they wouldn't call it work," and "You work to make money during the week so that you can enjoy the weekend." We're told that work is strenuous effort performed under the watchful eyes of authority. We're told we *have to work* to earn enough money to retire. Really? You're going to endure decades of misery and then what? What happens if you don't like retirement, or worse, if your health quickly deteriorates after you retire?

No. These beliefs about work are both common and incorrect. They are horribly misleading, and this book will attempt to dismantle them one by one.

Since we need to find a way of earning money, some people simply accept the first job they are offered. They don't give it much thought. Others spend more time thinking about their careers. They look for a secure and prestigious job. They like to tell others that they're an "Executive Director at National Bank" or that "I run my own business."

You might feel proud that you've landed a high-profile job or that you own a successful business. You are comforted that others believe you are doing something respectable.

But here's a quieter question that bubbles up beneath the surface: How does the work actually feel day in and day out, when no one's watching? Specifically, does the work give you energy or drain your energy?

At first, it's easy to gloss over this question. On the surface, social approval is comforting and hard to resist. Additionally, there's nothing inherently wrong with seeking security, prestige, or material comfort.

But if these external achievements become your primary focus, a quiet restlessness emerges.

Slowly, almost imperceptibly, you detect an uncomfortable feeling like a pebble in your emotional shoe. It's that unnerving sensation that something just doesn't feel quite right. It's your heart speaking to you, refusing to be misled by any logical argument constructed by your mind. Your heart insists on fulfillment and will keep sending you signals until it feels satisfied. The purpose of the mind is to set the heart free.

When something seems amiss, you can feel it in your gut, which contains approximately 300 million neurons and is often referred to as the second brain. Pay attention to this feeling. These neurons operate independently of your conscious thinking, which means they can sense psychological difficulties in a way that the logical brain cannot comprehend.

What Happens If You Ignore Your Gut Feeling?

It can be difficult to admit to other people that you don't feel good about your work, but you are not alone. Gallup surveys have revealed that 79% (more than three in four people) are disengaged at work.

When you find yourself in this situation, it can be extremely challenging. You may not enjoy the work, but you must earn a living. Your life may look good on the outside — working in a nice office with an impressive title at a reputable company — but on the inside, you feel hollow. It's an unsettling inner journey.

You wake with a sense of angst, not because the day ahead is particularly daunting, but because it feels painfully the same as yesterday. The projects on your desk often don't excite you and sometimes feel like an endless loop of monotony. Many people reach a point where the work that once challenged them now feels more like drudgery. The question is: Do you accept the drudgery and keep plowing forward? If so, to what degree are you selling your freedom for financial compensation?

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What dollar value do you place on your freedom?

When you reach this point, something within you starts to change. There's a gradual loss of self-respect from doing work that doesn't feel right. You might experience mood swings and grumpiness, or you may smile and laugh less frequently. Many report feeling understimulated yet overwhelmed.

You might feel flat — your energy drops and your creativity diminishes. You find it hard to focus and easy to procrastinate. Your interest in your craft declines, and you may experience a sinking feeling as you wonder whether you should do something different with your life.

I remember that sinking feeling all too well. While I worked in a corporate job, I felt my spirit was slowly being suffocated. But by working hard, I managed to numb myself to the dissatisfaction and the nagging feeling that I was wasting my potential. Every Sunday night, as I would prepare my clothes for the next day, that angst would creep in — a stark reminder that another week of soul-crushing monotony awaited me.

These psychological problems arise from doing work that you were never meant to do — work that clashes with your true nature. If you fail at a job, there's a clear signal that something needs to change. But what if you succeed? Paradoxically, excelling in a seemingly “good job” that you know isn't right for you poses a greater threat to your well-being because the social pressure to stay in this “good job” quietly breeds discontent. As author Jim Rohn reminds us, “If you are not willing to take a risk on the unusual, you will have to settle for the ordinary.”

With these inner life struggles, it's easy to become addicted to your phone so as to escape your emotional distress. Social media, TV, and video games numb the pain. Unfortunately, they also reduce the quality of your decisions. Poor mental health causes stress, leaving your body fatigued.

For some, electronic distractions will not suffice. You may reach for processed foods and then for something stronger. It might begin with alcohol and quietly spiral to something more destructive.

Given that 79% of people are disengaged at work, when do you think most people die? Studies have found that heart attacks are most common on Monday mornings, right at the start of the work week.

The worst part about dying at 9 a.m. on a Monday morning is the thoughts you have right before your death, knowing that you spiraled down a thoughtless path into a meaningless abyss.

The real trap is that this abyss didn't look like failure. It disguised itself as your success in that "good job," appearing rosy on the outside with pleasant conversations, fun hobbies, and respect from co-workers at the office. It is so appealing that your willful blindness became a voice of reason, divorcing you from your heart and coaxing you to enjoy the surface pleasures of life.

This was precisely the experience author Laurence Boldt had when he spoke to residents at a nursing home. He was struck by how many expressed regret about "things they always wanted to do with their lives, but hadn't done."

The worst part was not that they failed to achieve their dreams, but that they never even tried. Many had secretly nurtured ideas — sometimes for thirty or forty years — yet they never even took the first step.

On the other hand, Boldt mentions that there were a few who listened to their heart and lived their dreams. He observed how "they had an energy, a vitality, and a sense of humor that the others lacked... they seemed more at peace with themselves and with the prospect of death."

When asked if he feared dying, one such man said, "Death is not a problem if you have lived first." Sadly, Boldt noticed that his unmistakable vibrancy was a "rare exception in a sea of despair."

Boldt's experience highlights that failure is not the worst outcome. While failure might hurt temporarily, far worse is being permanently shackled by the fear of failure and never pursuing your deepest desires.

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This is a wicked spell that you must overcome. Regret stings the most when you have never tried and are left haunted by what might have been possible. When you explore your deepest desires, you win by listening to your intuition and doing your best with what you have, even if you fail to achieve the expected outcome. The experience provides wisdom, helping you to better navigate the future. But if you don't listen to your intuition, if you ignore your deepest desires, it's like taking a sledgehammer to the cockpit of a plane. You are destroying the navigation system, which hampers your ability to embark on your true path.

So How Do You Deal with This Situation?

You can ignore it. I did, for a while, but the confusion kept nagging at me. Know that it's okay to feel unsure. Most people are silently confused.

The moment you reach for your phone as an anesthetic to drown out your feelings is the very moment when you most need to pause. What is the real issue? It's usually not something that a job promotion or a vacation will solve. If you ignore this moment, the discomfort will reappear until it becomes so familiar, you barely even notice it.

So listen to the confusion. Own the confusion. Sit with the tension between your heart and mind. Embrace it like an old friend. Don't feel bad. Many people simply complain and never take action to change their situation. It takes courage to do the difficult work of confronting this challenge.

Consider your situation in light of this peculiar incident. In September 2012, a tour bus driver in southern Iceland stopped near a canyon to give passengers time to explore the surrounding area. The passengers returned, but the driver noticed that one guest was missing. He called the authorities, and when search and rescue arrived, the bus passengers joined in the search. A day later, a passenger realized that she was the missing person! She had changed clothes and the driver didn't recognize her.

Just like the woman who was searching for herself without realizing it, we too can become so absorbed in our pursuit of success that we lose sight of our true selves. You know that you want to be respected by others and to have enough money to live a comfortable life. But is that it?

This book offers you a moment to pause and reflect on what matters most to you. Think of it as a vacation from the rest of your life. You get to stop searching. While you read this book, reduce the notifications on social media so that more of your attention flows inward. By letting go of compulsive activity, you will have more headspace to confront the core issues in your life. When you reemerge into the world, your improved clarity will bring renewed vigor.

Life's hidden expiration dates highlight why clarity matters so much.

Why Life's Hidden Expiration Dates Are So Important

Let's look at the life of a typical person and do some simple math...

- There are 52 weeks in a year.
- Let's be optimistic and assume that medical technology keeps accelerating at its current pace. You look after your health and, as a result, manage to live to 100 years old.
- $100 \times 52 = 5,200$ weeks. If you live to 80, that's 4,160 weeks.

This diagram highlights the Stoic philosophy *memento mori*, which translates from Latin to "Remember you must die." One day, you will not be able to pursue the things that really matter to you. Your time on this planet is limited, and therefore, passively ignoring your unrealized potential is unacceptable.

Since you have a finite number of days left to live, there are only a finite number of times that you will do each activity. At the time of writing, I have eleven-year-old twins. I take them to school every day. It's hard for me to accept, but I know the day will come when I take them to school for the last time. Similarly, there will come a time when I see my good

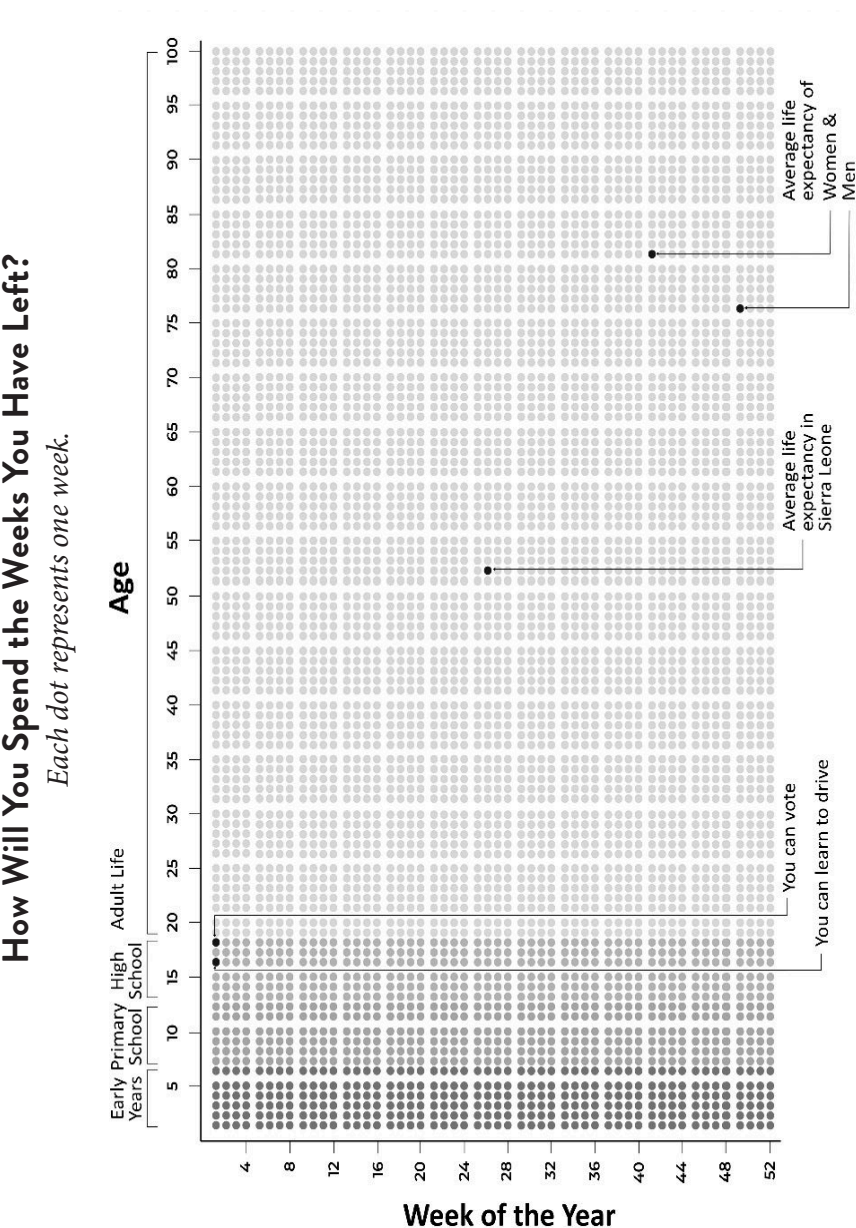


Figure 1: Your life in weeks. View an interactive version of this at: ChooseYourWorkBook.com/weeks

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friends who live overseas for the last time. It's not just that life is short. It's that life's most joyful activities have invisible expiration dates that only reveal themselves once they have slipped away.

When you become aware of these expiration dates, you embrace these moments more fully. You pause to consider what truly matters, because some things really do matter more than others.

Please note that the goal of this book is to help you pause long enough to get in touch with your deepest truth. So the value of this book only unfolds when you take the time to reflect and apply its message to your personal situation.

Please take a moment now, and at the end of each chapter, to complete a short reflection, capturing it in either your journal or the space provided.

The Three-Year Mirror

If I were forced to repeat my average day from the past week for the next three years, what is one thing I would change or stop doing?

Duration

Two minutes

You've just read a chapter about people who reached the end of their lives with regret. This reflection is your chance to avoid that scenario. Pause to consider whether your current path aligns with your deepest truth. Be brutally honest with yourself, even if it's uncomfortable. Small moments of self-reflection can illuminate the way forward and help you course-correct before it's too late.

Many find that writing by hand promotes deeper self-reflection and better memory retention. However, if typing or recording your thoughts feels more natural, choose what works best for you. The most important thing is to engage in the reflective process.

Feel free to exceed the suggested duration if you wish. This reflection is intentionally brief because small, consistent changes lead to life-changing results.

Write Your Reflections Here

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- ☐ I have noted what I might regret if I don't make any changes to my average day.
- ☐ I have circled the single most important insight or action to take.

In the Next Chapter...

Sometimes we are so entangled in our struggles that we fail to appreciate the value they offer. But in the next chapter, we'll explore how your greatest challenges may actually harbor hidden insights that can transform your work.

Praise for *Choose Your Work*

Choose Your Work is both deeply personal and profoundly universal. It is insightful, provocative, and quietly unsettling. It seamlessly blends research and real-world anecdotes with practical, step-by-step guidance to help you identify what matters most. This is a book for anyone who has ever sensed there must be more — more meaning, more joy, more alignment between who they are and the work they do.

Genia Janover | Award-Winning Former Principal | Bialik College | Former Fellow | Australian College of Educators

Dan Dobos says the scary, quiet thing out loud: how we spend our working lives is a choice. *Choose Your Work* is both a wake-up call and a practical roadmap for anyone ready to make that choice.

Ben Stickland | Co-Founder & CEO | Instamove

This is the kind of book I will go back to regularly. Some self-help books you read once. Others bring value over and over throughout your life. This is the latter.

Teshia Harding

Choose Your Work distills a lifetime of insights and wisdom into a practical guide to help you clarify what matters most.

Jonar Nader | Former IBM Executive | Author of *How to Lose Friends & Infuriate Your Boss*

Chapter Two alone helped me more than therapy has.

Kayla Giles

Choose Your Work is a timely and deeply needed guide for anyone who senses there must be more to work than simply earning a living. In a volatile world that pushes people toward conformity, this book offers a practical and thought-provoking path back to what truly matters.

Mark Bowles | Dean, Tasmanian School of Business and Economics | University of Tasmania

In my work as a psychotherapist, I see how easy it is to lose sight of who you truly are. *Choose Your Work* offers a thoughtful and compelling path back to yourself.

Kirk Fisher | Psychotherapist & Zen Teacher

Honest, raw, and real. *Choose Your Work* was exactly what I needed.

Christy Oshima

Unlike other career change manuals, this is a guide for those searching for fulfilling work that is both optimistic and encouraging.

Helen Praetz | Emeritus Professor and Former Pro Vice-Chancellor | RMIT University

If you know someone graduating college, buy them this book. If a friend just turned 30, buy them this book. Most people stumble into careers that 'kinda work' and there they remain stuck. Don't be like most people. Buy this book.

James Tuckerman | Founder | Anthill Magazine

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**Have you ever felt the unnerving sensation that,
despite appearing successful, something deep down isn't quite right?**

When you look back at your life, will you be satisfied?
Or will you have regrets?

The dark side of grit is chasing goals that don't matter,
while your deepest desires quietly fade away.

The way forward is to realize that the secret to a
fulfilling life is to choose your work.

**In this thought-provoking book, packed with inspiration,
practical strategies, and insightful stories, you will discover...**

What is more valuable than \$100 million in cold hard cash?

•

How to extract insights from your greatest challenges to realize your potential

•

Strategies to choose your work while still paying the bills

•

Why being good at something may lead you down the
wrong path and how to find the right one

•

Why focusing on comfort can ruin your life and
obscure the true metrics of success



**This book will help you discover your deepest truth, redefine what
success means to you, and begin a fulfilling new chapter in your journey.**

"Compelling and thought-provoking. It inspired immediate action in my life."

Beau Florenosos

"Inspirational, memorable and unlike any self-help book I've read before."

Jean Rose Dogillo

"Engaging, energising and deeply thought-provoking."

Liz Treat